Source: ECI: Analysis by Nalin Mehta, Rishabh Srivastava, PollNiti.

'A Party of Both the Rural and the Town': The BJP's Rurban Rise

It is not just rural seats. The BJP showed the same pattern of growth in rurban seats as well. Of the seventy-nine rurban seats in the Hindi heartland, its MPs got elected from 24 per cent in 2009, 91.1 per cent in 2014 and 86 per cent in 2019. Again, until 2014, these poll victories could have been dismissed as only skin-deep and easily reversible. In 2019, however, the BJP gained significant voter depth in these areas, even though its seat share reduced slightly. In these very same Hindi heartland rurban seats, the party won more than 40 per cent votes in only 13.9 per cent constituencies in 2009, 82.2 per cent in 2014 and an astounding 94.9 per cent in 2019. Zoom in further on UP, and we see the same pattern of horizontal widening of the BJP's rurban base. Of twenty-eight rurban seats in UP, it went from winning just 20.7 per cent in 2009 to 96.4 per cent in 2014 and then to 75 per cent in 2019. Again, vote shares in these rurban parliamentary constituencies show a growing base for the party: more than 40 per cent of votes in zero seats in 2009, 78.5 per cent in 2014 and a whopping 92.8 per cent in 2019 (see Figures 2.4 and 2.5).

When I put these numbers to Keshav Prasad Maurya, the BJP's deputy chief minister in UP, in June 2020, his response was unambiguous. 'The BJP is a party of the poor,' he said. When we met at his residence at Lucknow's Kalidas Marg, the first COVID-19 lockdown was on. Besides the regular security metal detectors at the entrance, there were now also two gates with overhead sprinklers that blew clouds of sanitising liquid over visitors. Once inside, we observed all social-distancing norms as we conversed in his residential office. I had just travelled 1,000 km across UP researching rural areas for this book. When I asked him whether he thought that the BJP was now predominantly a rural party, he answered emphatically: 'BPL cards were always there. They were made in 2002. But when we went to the people for 2017 and 2019 elections, there were many who had reached the sky from the